

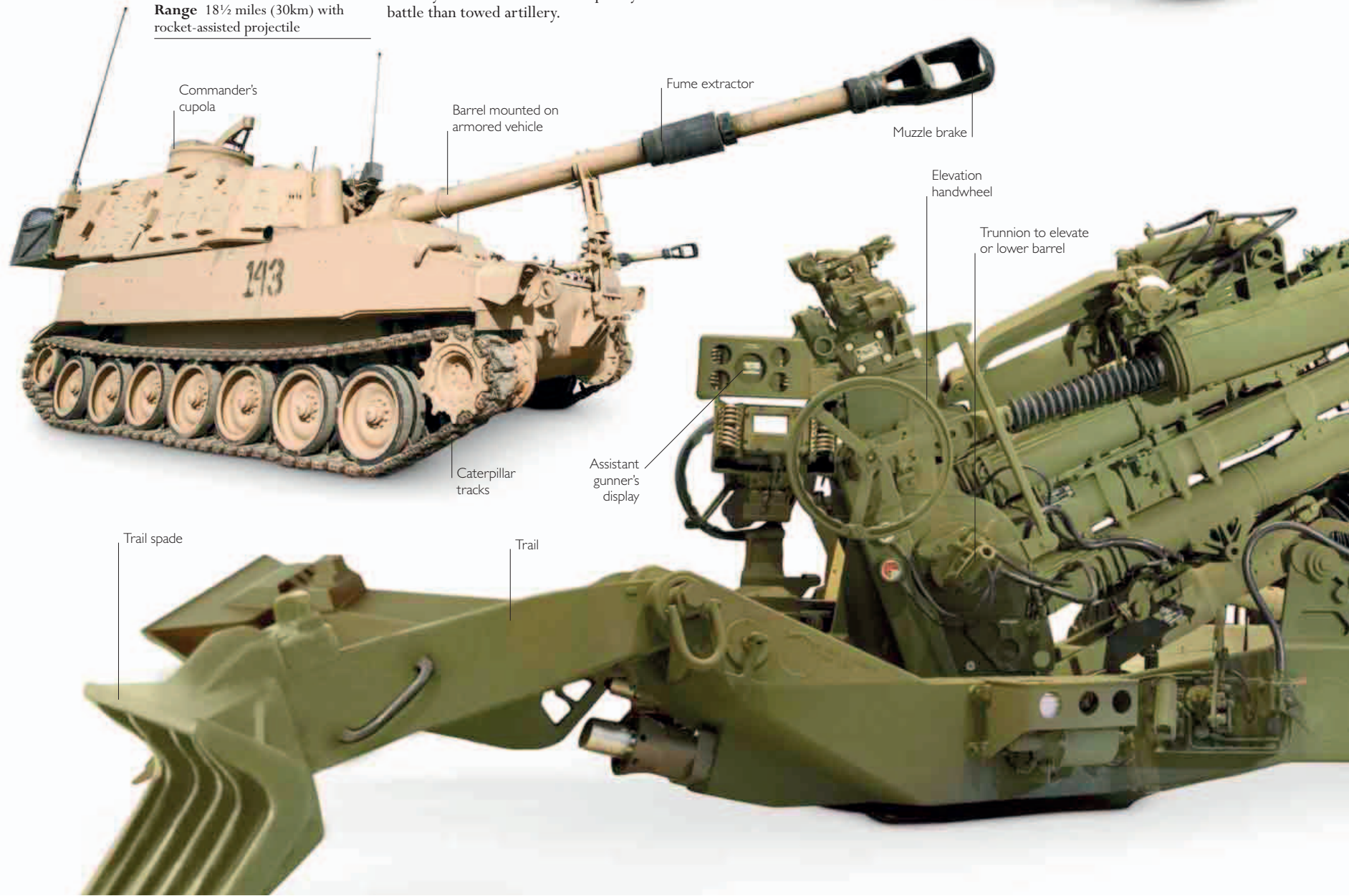
MODERN ARTILLERY (1946–PRESENT)

Since World War II, artillery in fixed positions has died out due to the threat of being destroyed from the air. Modern artillery is mobile—either towed, self-propelled, or even air-portable by helicopter, as in the case of the lightweight M777. Conventional artillery (that firing shells rather than rockets) includes howitzers and field guns. Towed artillery is generally 4.13–6.10in (105–155mm) in caliber and has become ever more precise in its targeting, using indirect fire—where the target cannot be seen—and benefitting from technologies such as the Global Positioning System (GPS). This is especially useful for longer guns, which can now achieve ranges of up to 30 miles (50km). Despite these advances, most artillery weapons used in conflicts today are designs that originated in the Soviet Union. Examples such as the D20 are simple, robust, and reliable.

▼ M109 HOWITZER

Date	1963
Origin	US
Length	29¾ft (9.1m)
Caliber	155mm
Range	18½ miles (30km) with rocket-assisted projectile

The term howitzer is now used for a range of different artillery weapons. The M109 Howitzer is the main self-propelled howitzer of the US Army and is in use in many other countries. Self-propelled artillery can be activated more quickly in battle than towed artillery.



▼ D20
Date 1950s
Origin Soviet Union
Length 28½ft (8.7m)
Caliber 152mm
Range 15 miles (24km) with rocket-assisted projectile

Soviet-made artillery is commonly used in conflicts around the world. The rugged D20 is a manually loaded towed howitzer. The gun's barrel is mounted on a cradle, which houses a recoil system. This includes a recuperator, which enables the gun's barrel to return to its firing position after recoil.

Cradle

Commander's cupola

Barrel mounted on armored vehicle

Fume extractor

Muzzle brake

Elevation handwheel

Trunnion to elevate or lower barrel

Assistant gunner's display

Caterpillar tracks

Trail spade

Trail